Nahal Oz is an idyllic kibbutz on the Gaza border, a friendly village surrounded by rolling fields where the anemones bloom in spring. During the war, though, it was a ghost town: it was evacuated early on, like others in the area, and was almost empty when I visited in late July, save for a detachment of soldiers camped on the outskirts. In mid-August, however, with the fighting seemingly on the wane, community leaders urged residents to come back. The Israeli army encouraged it too. Dozens of families returned, including the Tragermans, but their happiness at being home was short-lived: the rocket fire continued.

They were packing their bags to leave again on the afternoon of 22 August when the siren went off. The Tragermans grabbed their two youngest children and ran for the shelter. But their eldest son, Daniel, didn't make it. A mortar hit a parked car nearby, and the shrapnel killed him. He was four years old.

He became the face of Israel's grief on social media and the front pages of newspapers: a photo of a young boy with tousled hair and a mischievous grin, wearing an oversized Messi jersey. He was "a boy too small to cross the road, because it is dangerous, but big enough to know what rocket sirens are," Rivlin said at his funeral. His death left a deep scar on Nahal Oz. Roughly one-fifth of the population—more than a dozen families, including the Tragermans—decided not to return after the ceasefire. (Two more civilians were killed by mortar fire in Nirim, a nearby kibbutz, hours before the ceasefire went into effect.)

A war, to what end?

It was hard to explain why Daniel Tragerman died—or indeed any of the other 2,200 people who lost their lives that summer. At the outset of the war, Israel's motto was "quiet for quiet": if Hamas stops firing rockets, we'll stop firing back. Netanyahu wanted a rerun of 2012. Hamas didn't. It had demands. Reasonable ones, many Palestinians agreed, like lifting the years-old blockade of the strip—a demand the Israeli government was unwilling to meet. So it kept shooting. "Hamas is willing to be practical in its behavior," said David Hacham, the defense ministry's top adviser for Arab affairs. "But we also need to speak about what's happening on the ground. It's not willing to give in on strategic demands."